The South African A team flew home and prepared to play two four-day matches against New Zealand A, with the first starting at SuperSport Park in Centurion on Wednesday, 8 September 2004. The touring side won the toss and reached 241 for seven by stumps at the end of an unremarkable first day. The Kiwi tail wagged on the second morning and they were eventually bowled out for 328 just before lunch.

I had kept wicket during their innings and then quickly switched pads to open our innings with Andrew Puttick, from Western Province. Eager to play some strokes, I hit four boundaries and raced to 30 from 25 balls. It was fun until, in the ninth over, I was out, caught behind off the medium-paced bowling of Chris Martin with our total at 43 for one. We reached 136 for four by the close of the second day, and appeared well placed.

All seemed well when the players started to arrive at the ground on the third morning of the match, on Friday, 10 September.

But very soon all was not well.

'AB de Villiers, you will never play in a team coached by me again!'

Ray Jennings had called a team meeting before we went out to warm up, and it quickly became clear that the coach was extremely angry and that there was one subject on his mind ... me.

He was going ballistic.

'Who the hell do you think you are, De Villiers? You walk in and you are so loose. You don't respect the opposition and you don't respect the game. That attitude is going to cost us. It's not good enough for this team and I promise you won't play in my team again.'

He was not finished. There was no discussion about the game or our plan for the day.

He continued: 'It's just not acceptable ...'

Ashwell Prince, our captain, eventually intervened. 'Ray, it's fine,' he said. 'Ray, let's focus on the game now.'

I was shocked, speechless. Several teammates came over afterwards